Although both the PNO and PNLO claim to represent Pa-O people, the rift between the two is not simply caused by ideological differences, but also has been encouraged by divide-and-rule tactics. The SSNPLO tried to reconcile with the PNO after the CPB broke up, however, the PNO refused reconciliation as many of its leaders were assassinated during the two decades of intra-Pa-O fighting (Christensen and Sann Kyaw 2006; Smith 1999). In 2010, the PNO registered as a political party and won all the seats in Special Region 6. In contrast, even though the PNLO also signed a ceasefire agreement, it has remained as a ceasefire armed group and has no other legal status.[2]

Under the more pluralistic political environment in Myanmar since 2011, the Union Pa-O National Organization (UPNO) registered as a political party in 2013 on the claim that the PNO is corrupt and working for the government.[3] However, the party lacks financial resources and cannot seriously challenge the PNO's position. In 2015 it failed to win any of the ten seats it contested at the national election.

Along with a new political party came a revival of community sector organizations (CSOs). Most have mandates to promote democracy and build capacity among Pa-O people, which puts them in direct confrontation with the PNO. The Kaung Rwai Social Action Network (KRSAN) runs a centre to teach Pa-O youth English, and is actively involved in pro-democracy campaigns. The Democracy for Ethnic Minorities Organization (DEMO) has a similar agenda. The Pa-O Youth Organization (PYO) acts as a claim-maker to raise social and environmental issues. As a damage-control strategy, the PNO set up the Parami Development Network (PDN) in 2012 to fund the renovation of pagodas, and to build roads and schools. Pa-O villagers who benefited from the renovations appear to appreciate these projects.[4]

The actors in the Shan community

The political actors in the southern Shan State come from more diverse backgrounds than in the Pa-O community. The most obvious actors are state representatives and Shan ethnic political actors. However, because of the importance of its location, the area also attracts political actors and activists from other parts of the country.

Shan ethnic armed groups resisted state authority in the southern Shan State after independence. In the beginning, the resistance was fragmented. Then the military coup by Ne Win in 1962 helped to unify the